Sales Training — Session 41

Cement, Then Negotiate.

Price and Terms — The Only Two Objections That Actually Matter.

Monday 13 July 2026 · Marketing Sweet

WHAT THIS SESSION IS How to handle the two objections that account for almost every buyer who's ready to buy but stops short of signing. Cement the position early. Get the verbal commitment before you walk away. Add referrals as the counterweight when the buyer wants a discount. Trial close along the way. Use the phrase "I want your business" when it's true. And break the pattern deliberately on feedback so the team hears what actually matters.

1. The 12-month objection — the actual asked question

A rep brought the specific case to the session. Client had a good meeting. Buyer is happy to come on board. The only thing holding them back: the 12-month contract length. Buyer has been burnt before, or has never done marketing, and doesn't want to be locked in. The rep asked: how do you overcome the objection in the meeting?

The session's answer starts with a reframe. Buyers who fixate on the exit at the moment of committing to the entrance are like people asking about the prenup at the wedding — they're looking for a way OUT before they've said yes to being IN. That's a signal about how the pitch was structured, not just about the buyer. If the 12-month conversation is happening at the END of the meeting, the rep has lost the negotiation before they've entered it. The 12 months needs to be raised at the START, casually and confidently, so it's baked into the deal the buyer is already saying yes to — not treated as a final gotcha at the finish line.

> *"People worried about 12 months at the end are treating it like a prenup at the wedding — looking for an exit before they've said yes. If you introduce it at the end, you've lost. Cement it at the start."*

2. Cement the position — the word is "obviously"

The specific verbal move to build the 12-month term into the pitch WITHOUT drawing attention to it as an objection. Early in the pitch — after value has started building but before pricing — the rep drops a single word: "obviously." As in: "Obviously all our packages are a minimum 12-month term — we need time to actually get you results." The word does two things at once. It signals to the buyer that the 12-month structure isn't negotiable (it's stated as a given, not an option). And it does so casually enough that the buyer processes it as background context, not as a hostile term.

Compare the alternative. Rep gets to the end of the meeting, quotes the price, hands over the paperwork, and says "oh, one thing — this is a 12-month agreement." The buyer's guard goes up. They feel it as a surprise, treat it as a bargaining chip, and push back. "Can we do six months? Month to month?" The rep is now negotiating from an uncemented position —

the term wasn't part of the offer the buyer accepted, so it feels like it's up for grabs. Once that door opens, it's very hard to close.

> *""Obviously all our packages are minimum 12 months — we need time to get you results." One word. "Obviously." Said early. It cements the position without making it a fight."*

3. Once it's cemented, negotiate — but only for a verbal commitment

Cementing doesn't mean refusing to move. It means moving from a stronger position. If the buyer still pushes back on the term after the position is cemented, the rep now asks the pivotal question — one worth memorising word for word: "If it wasn't for the 12 months, would you definitely go ahead today?"

Notice what the question does. It surfaces whether the term is the ONLY remaining blocker, or whether the buyer is using it as a proxy for other doubts. If they say "yes" — the term is the only blocker. Now the rep has a verbal commitment to close AGAINST. If they hedge ("well, I'd also want to think about it more..."), then the term isn't the real issue — something else is, and the rep needs to keep listening. Either answer is useful. The question sorts the two very different situations.

> *""If it wasn't for the 12 months, would you definitely go ahead today?" Ask it clean. The answer sorts the deal. Yes → you have a verbal commitment. Hedge → the term isn't the real issue."*

If the answer is yes, the rep now says: "Okay, leave it with me. I don't think I can get to six, but let me see what I can do. If I CAN get you to six months, you're saying you're happy to go ahead today?" Get the second confirmation. NOW walk away to "check with the director." The director is theatre — the answer might be yes, might be no, sometimes shouldn't be. But by the time the rep comes back with the answer, the buyer has committed twice, verbally, to closing conditional on that variable. That's the position from which deals get done.

4. Two reasons buyers don't close — and only two

The central diagnostic principle of the session. Any buyer who's genuinely interested in the product but stops short of signing is stopping for one of two reasons. Price, or terms. Not "I need to think about it." Not "my partner has to approve." Not "I want to sleep on it." Underneath all those surface objections, the actual blocker is either the price is too high or the terms don't work. Once the rep internalises this, the closing conversation becomes dramatically simpler — the rep only needs to isolate which of the two, then work on that one.

Buyers who aren't going to close for other reasons — genuine lack of interest, no budget at all, wrong fit — those aren't real deals. They shouldn't be worked as though they were. But for the deals that ARE real — the buyer who genuinely wants what's on offer — price or terms is the entire universe of what can stop the sale. Everything else is a symptom. Get to the symptom, isolate it, work on it.

> *"There are only two reasons a genuine buyer doesn't close: price or terms. Everything else is a symptom of one of those two. Isolate which. Work on that."*

5. The isolation question — "so if we get X right, we can do a deal?"

The verbal move that surfaces which of the two is blocking the deal. Once the rep suspects price is the sticking point, they ask: "Can I ask you a question? So, what you mean to say to me is the price is the only thing holding this back. If we get the price where you want it, we can do the deal?" The buyer either says yes (isolated — price is it), or reveals another issue ("well, and I'd also want to shorten the term..."). Either way, the rep now knows what the deal actually needs.

This is the same structure as the 12-month question in Section 3, applied to price. Both work the same way. Both should be in the rep's core toolkit, delivered verbatim, from memory. Reps who improvise around these questions get soft, ambiguous answers that don't sort the deal. Reps who ask them cleanly get the clean sorting they need to close.

> *"So if we get you to $850 — you're saying we can do a deal today?" Get the yes. Then walk away and see what you can do. Only two objections. Isolate the one. Work it."*

6. Never just accept the discount — add referrals to balance

The most important tactical move on the pricing side. When the buyer asks for a discount and the rep can grant it, the WORST possible response is "yes, I can do that for you." That reply lands as a scam — the buyer immediately thinks "why didn't you offer me that price in the first place?" The value proposition collapses. Even though the buyer got what they asked for, they walk away with less trust, less commitment, and more suspicion. Some of them cancel within a week.

The corrective is the value-proposition seesaw. On one side of the seesaw sits the price. On the other side sits the value of the product. The two need to be roughly balanced — the buyer's brain accepts a deal that feels balanced. When the rep drops the price, weight comes off the price side of the seesaw, and the value side automatically feels HEAVIER — which is the buyer thinking "is there something wrong with this that they're dropping the price so easily?" To rebalance the seesaw, the rep needs to add weight to the price side — i.e. get the buyer to contribute something back.

The move: "Can I ask you a question? How many people do you know in business? Could you give me just two names — mates you'd be happy to refer to us, on the condition that we do a great job for you? I'm pretty confident I can get this discount through the director, but the referrals give me the ammunition to make it happen."

> *"Take price off, put referrals on. The seesaw stays balanced. The buyer feels the deal is fair — and you've bought yourself an insurance policy that they hold you accountable to deliver. Everyone wins. Nobody feels scammed."*

The genius of the move — noted in earlier sessions and worth restating here — is that the referrals also function as an accountability contract. The buyer has just told the rep who they'd refer. That means the rep has skin in the game to actually deliver, because bad service now costs the rep those warm referral contacts. The insurance policy runs both ways. That's the invisible value the buyer feels — even if they can't articulate it — when the discount arrives WITH the referral trade.

7. The bell curve — sell to the middle

A useful reframe of who the rep is actually pitching to. Any market has a distribution of buyer types. On the far wing sit price-obsessive outliers — they'll buy a 50-cent pie scraped off the floor as long as it's cheap. On the other wing sit value-obsessive outliers — they'll pay premium prices without much attention to the number, as long as the value is genuinely there. Both wings are small. The middle 60-80% is the actual market. That's who the rep is selling to.

This matters because the moves that WORK on the wings can BLOW UP on the middle. Drop the price too aggressively and the middle buyer gets suspicious ("why so cheap? what's wrong?"). Pitch too aggressively on premium value and the middle buyer switches off ("this isn't for me"). The middle buyer wants a considered price they can defend to themselves, sitting alongside a value proposition they can point to. Both. In balance. Not one or the other.

> *"Don't play with outliers. Sell to the middle. The 50-cent pie shocks the middle. The $50 pie without the story shocks the middle. Land the price where it makes sense, with the value story that supports it."*

8. Deal detection — slow down when it's a deal, move through when it's not

A calibration skill the session named explicitly. Every call has a rhythm. Reps who read the rhythm well pace the call accordingly. When the deal is genuinely there — buying signals present, buyer engaging, questions coming from the buyer rather than the rep — the rep slows down. Every word matters more. Trial closes become more important. The rep doesn't rush the buyer toward the yes.

When the deal isn't there — flat responses, deflections, mismatched energy — the rep moves through the pitch more quickly. Not to give up, but to test whether anything lands. If nothing does, the rep wraps up cleanly and moves to the next call. Time spent on dead calls is time not spent on live ones. The rep's ability to recognise dead calls quickly and live calls slowly is one of the highest-leverage skills they can develop.

> *"When the deal is there, slow down. When it's not, get through it. Reps who confuse the two burn time on the wrong calls and rush the right ones."*

A practical tool the session suggested: a piece of paper with blue tack, flipped between "deal" and "no deal" during the call as signals emerge. Physical prompt to keep the rep's pacing decision conscious rather than reflexive. Over time the flip happens automatically — but until then, the physical object helps.

9. The bomb-defusing analogy — offer maximum resistance

The right mental image for how the rep should handle the discount conversation. A bomb-defusing expert doesn't cut wires quickly. They study the wires. They identify the right one. They cut it slowly, deliberately, with maximum care. Rushing gets the bomb-defuser killed. Selling with a discount ask is structurally the same. Rushing the discount kills the value proposition. Taking time with it — offering resistance, checking with the director, coming back with a considered response — keeps the value proposition intact.

So when a buyer asks for a discount, the rep's first move is resistance. "I don't think I can get there — but let me see." Silence. Slow down. Take the ask seriously as a negotiation, not as a request to be granted. Even if the rep KNOWS they can grant the discount, the buyer has to feel that the discount was hard-won for it to land as valuable. Discounts given freely are worth less than the same discount fought for. Same money. Completely different perceived value.

> *"Take your time. Offer maximum resistance. If you say "yeah, we can do that" too fast, you've cut the wrong wire. The bomb blows up — the value proposition dies."*

10. Trial closes — "does that all make sense so far?"

A specific verbal move for the middle-to-end of the meeting. As the rep works through the pitch, they build in checkpoints — small confirming questions that test whether the buyer is still on board. "Does that make sense?" "Any concerns about that part?" "Am I explaining it clearly?" Each checkpoint is a trial close. The buyer's answer tells the rep whether to keep going or to slow down and address something.

The critical word: "so far." "Does that all make sense SO FAR?" tells the buyer there's still ground to cover — they're not being asked to commit yet. That preserves the buyer's psychological safety. Without the "so far," a buyer who's still nervous may retreat into "I need to think about it" prematurely — because the question felt like it was demanding a decision. With the "so far," the buyer can say yes without committing to anything final.

> *""Does that all make sense so far?" Two extra words. Enormous difference. "So far" tells the buyer there's road ahead. They can say yes without feeling cornered."*

11. "I want your business" — vulnerability + directness

A specific verbal move worth learning verbatim. Near the end of the closing conversation — after the pitch, after the objection surfacing, before the ask — the rep drops a sentence most reps never say: "I want your business." Plain, direct, vulnerable. Not "I'd love to work with you," not "we'd be a great fit" — those are hedged. "I want your business" is naked. The rep has just told the buyer they care about the outcome specifically, personally.

Most buyers aren't used to hearing this. It breaks the pattern of the corporate pitch, where the rep pretends detachment. The vulnerability of the sentence lands as sincerity. The buyer feels the rep's actual investment in the outcome — and buyers who feel that investment are significantly more likely to reciprocate. It's the same dynamic as a romantic relationship, applied to a business one. Saying "I want to be with you" is uncomfortable. It also produces yes answers that hedging never does.

> *""I want your business." Say it. It's vulnerable, and that's the point. It breaks the pattern of the standard sales script — which is why it works."*

The pairing to remember: "I want your business — what would we need to do to make this work?" Vulnerability + a question that puts the ball in the buyer's court. Together they produce the warm, inviting closing conversation the session named as the mark of a professional. Cold, mechanical closes don't produce yes; warm, direct ones do.

12. Break the pattern — head versus heart on feedback

A cultural principle worth carrying beyond the pitch. Most people, by default, do the opposite of what they should with feedback. When they hear criticism, they take it to heart — where it produces depression, self-doubt, defensiveness. When they hear praise, they take it to the head — where they intellectualise it, discount it, and move on. Both defaults are backwards.

The corrective is deliberate pattern-breaking. Take criticism to the HEAD — process it intellectually, note the specific correction, apply it, move on. Don't marinate. Don't spiral. Take praise to the HEART — let it register emotionally, believe it, carry it as fuel. Especially when the praise comes from someone whose word means something (a boss, a mentor, a trusted colleague), the praise is DATA — the same way criticism is data. Both are gifts. Reversing the default response to each of them is one of the highest-leverage mindset changes any rep can make.

> *"When the boss says you're off course — take it to the head. When the boss says you're doing a great job — take it to the heart. Most people do it backwards. That's why most people stay stuck."*

13. Action items for the team

1. Introduce the 12-month term at the START of the pitch, casually, using the word "obviously." "Obviously all our packages are minimum 12 months — we need time to get you results."

2. Memorise the verbal commitment question: "If it wasn't for the 12 months, would you definitely go ahead today?" Ask it clean. Wait for the answer.
3. Memorise the price isolation question: "So if we get the price where you want it, we can do the deal?" Get the yes before you go check with the director.
4. When a buyer asks for a discount and you can grant it, DON'T just say yes. Add the referral counterweight: "Give me two names of people you'd refer if we do a great job for you."
5. Print a small sign: DEAL / NO DEAL. Flip it during calls as signals emerge. Slow down on DEAL calls. Move through NO DEAL calls. Manage your time by the flip.
6. Add "so far" to your trial closes. "Does that all make sense SO FAR?" Two extra words. Enormous difference in the buyer's psychological safety.
7. Use "I want your business" on the next five closing conversations where you genuinely mean it. Watch how buyers respond to the vulnerability.
8. Practice the head/heart swap on feedback for one week. When you hear criticism, note it and move on (head). When you hear praise, sit with it (heart). Reverse the defaults deliberately.

THE RULE OF THUMB There are only two reasons a genuine buyer doesn't close: price or terms. Cement the terms early with "obviously." Isolate whether it's price or terms with the "if it wasn't for X" question. Get a verbal commitment before you walk away. When you drop the price, add referrals to keep the seesaw balanced. Trial close with "so far." And when you mean it — say "I want your business."